

RELIGIOUS REVIVAL

OLD WORLD VALUES: Saraswati Sishu Vidya Mandir in Patna



relax and play, say their prayers and have dinner at 8 p.m. There are arguments that the curriculum should include professional courses, but the staff doesn't agree. "Ours is no ordinary school that prepares a student only for this world. Here we prepare you for this world and the next," says a caretaker at the school. The Bihar State Madrasa Education Board says the region has 1,118 madrasas.

Religion makes a comeback as people search for an identity. Ironically, this search ends in madrasas and RSS-run schools where young boys and girls head for an education based on religion, a pointer that good quality, inexpensive education still eludes the poor.

Confined to the rigours of another religion, 14-year-old Amit Kumar does not resent it, but teachers of the

RSS-run Saraswati Shishu Vidya Mandir at Phulwarisharif, Patna, value discipline so much that they take personal interest in the private life of this Class X student. The brightest in his class, Kumar magnanimously surrenders all credit for his success to the gurus. "Our teachers value discipline and dedication," says the IIT aspirant. He misses cricket, just as Class VI student Nibha Kumari longs for badminton, because the school encourages only kabaddi, khokho and athletics. Students recite Sanskrit shlokas, chant the bhojan mantra before their meals, say a morning prayer and sing *Vande mataram*. The teachers are "Acharyaji" who address girls as *behen* and boys as *bhaiyya* and they have strict instructions to "keep their eyes off each other."

As one India chases a global identity, the other retreats into a conservative cocoon. ■

BAL THACKERAY, chief, Shiv Sena, 1989

"Where will the Hindus go if the government and the minorities keep behaving the way they do?"